Centering Digitality. An interdisciplinary and discursive research network

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The poster presents the concept and rationale of the newly installed Interdisciplinary Centre for Digitality and Digital Methods at Campus Mitte of Humboldt Universität zu Berlin (IC D2MCM).[1] The IC focuses both on digitality and digital methods as an epistemical construct and bridges diverse fields such as Digital Humanities (DH), social sciences, media and cultural studies, law, economics, and religious studies[2] . Our centre is a hub for interdisciplinary collaboration, connecting researchers, educators, and students[3] from six faculties and an institute within HU Berlin and beyond the university's borders[4] . Our work emphasises digitality as a central research objective, fostering theoretical exploration and practical applications with a strong focus on AI and data literacy in DH and related fields[5] . The centre, even though we are still in an early implementation phase, fosters collaboration between otherwise not connected fields and colleagues (cf. this contribution; workshops on git or LLM and different outputs of working groups[6]) and is able to function as a broker within the HU Berlin for our requirements on organisational level. In addition, we aim to complement the existing landscape of Digital Humanities centres and to contribute to the vibrant discussions and research about the development of DH team, centres and labs within the community (cf. current discussions e.g. Pawlicka-Deger and Thomson 2024).

The methodological spectrum of Digital Humanities often addresses all aspects of the entire research data life cycle (cf. for an overview Cox and Tam 2018): design (e.g. Bode 2023, early Biber 1998 and Hunston 2008), annotation modeling and application (e.g. Ciula et al. 2023, Flanders and Jannidis 2019, Zeldes 2018), analysis (quantitative, qualitative, close or distant reading e.g. Primorac et al. 2023, Graham et al. 2022, Jänicke et al. 2015), and visualisation (e.g. Bubenhofer 2020, Drucker 2020) in conjunction with appropriate research software (e.g. for search and visualisation Krause and Zeldes 2016, for analysis and visualisation Sinclair and Rockwell 2016, for data wrangling OpenRefine[7] , publishing tools like TEI Publisher[8]). There is also an intensive epistemic discussion about, e.g., the scope, reliability or/and conclusions with respect to the results and interpretation of data-based empiric approaches (cf. e.g. Da 2019). However, the rich and extensive methodological focus needs to be completed by a meta-binding theoretical concept: digitality.

Our centre's goal to contribute to digitality as an epistemological construct is reflected by the *Reading and Writing Lab*[9] which investigates digitality as a crucially interdisciplinary concept at the core of Digital Humanities. We consider this to be an essential condition for the adequate development and application of digital methods and data. Among the constitutive components of digitality in the humanities are: **modeling and representation** (cf. McCarthy 2004, Barberousse and Ludwig 2009, Heßbrüggen-Walter 2016), **algorithms** and **formalization** as well as fundamental **mediality** (e.g. Hiltmann 2022). We contextualise and critically reflect these aspects within philosophical (cf. Krämer 2024), historical (cf. Nyhan and Flinn 2016), and cultural and media studies (cf. Stalder 2016; Chun 2018; Siegert 2023, Miyazaki 2023). These constitutive components influence (in-)directly how we design, create and analyse data on the one hand. On the other hand, they (in-)directly set requirements for the methods and tools applied to the data. Consequently, digitality also relates in different ways to software (modeling, development and application). Our work contributes to understanding the interplay of these components leading to a theoretical concept of digitality. In addition, we would like to investigate the historical, social, and material conditions and potentialities of digitality. We are interested in how digitality transforms methodologies, reshapes epistemic categories, and opens new theoretical perspectives. By addressing these questions and offering interdisciplinary infrastructures, we enrich the DH community and promote innovative research.

Notes

1. https://izd2m.hu-berlin.de , accessed 27/11/2024.
2. Faculty of Language, Literature and Humanities, Faculty of Arts and Humanities, Faculty of Economics and Business Administration, Faculty of Law, Faculty of Theology, Faculty of Humanities and Social Sciences, Berlin Institute for Islamic Theology: https://izd2m.hu-berlin.de/content_en/about_en.html , accessed 27/11/2024.
3. Early Career researcher Panel: https://izd2m.hu-berlin.de/content_en/ecr-panel/ecr-panel_en.html accessed 27/11/2024. Co working space for students: https://izd2m.hu-berlin.de/events/2024-11-29-coworking-space.html , accessed 27/11/2024.
4. Research Institutions in Digital Social and Cultural studies and Humanities: RIDSCH: https://izd2m.hu-berlin.de/content_en/events/2025-01-24_netzwerkevent-ridsch_en.html ,accessed 27/11/2024.
5. https://izd2m.hu-berlin.de/content_en/events_archive/events_archive_en.html , accessed 27/11/2024.
6. E.g. collaboration working group Git+ : Odebrecht, Carolin, Thomas Krause, Martin Klotz, Christine Mooshammer, und Melanie Althage. „Corpus Data Teaching Workflow Board". Zenodo, 5. Februar 2025. https://doi.org/10.5281/ZENODO.14810639 .
7. https://openrefine.org/ ,
8. https://teipublisher.com/ , accessed 27/11/2024.
9. Working Group Reading and Writing Lab: Digitality https://izd2m.hu-berlin.de/content_en/wg/digitality/digitality_about_en.html , accessed 27/11/2024.

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